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Morning Edition

Ocean governance, hydrospatial science & SIDS equity, curated for Francesca Adrienne

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COP1 Is Set. The Clearing-House Fight Starts Now.

01

The rulebook for the water outside anyone's jurisdiction just cleared its last drafting stage, and COP1 in January 2027 is where you get a formal seat at deciding how area-based management tools actually get proposed and vetted, which is the exact machinery HARMONiSE needs to plug into.

STORY NOTES

PrepCom3 wrapped in New York on 2 April 2026, the third and final preparatory session before the BBNJ Agreement's first Conference of the Parties. Delegates locked down rules of

STORY ARTICLE

COP1 for the BBNJ Agreement is now fixed for January 2027, and the path there closed on 2 April 2026 when PrepCom3 finished its two-week session at UN Headquarters. This was the third and final

procedure, secretariat arrangements, funding channels through the Global Environment Facility, and the operational shape of the Clearing-House Mechanism, then forwarded the whole package to COP1, now scheduled for January 2027.

For you this is not abstract diplomacy. BBNJ's core tools, marine protected area proposals and environmental impact assessments in areas beyond national jurisdiction, run through a Clearing-House Mechanism that is still being built. Whoever shapes its early data standards shapes what counts as usable evidence, and that is a hydrospatial data question before it is a legal one.

preparatory meeting under the Agreement, and its job was mechanical rather than dramatic: lock down the rules of procedure, agree how the secretariat will function, settle the Agreement's relationship with the Global Environment Facility, and decide the operational shape of the Clearing-House Mechanism before handing all of it to the first Conference of the Parties for adoption.

None of that sounds like it touches your work. It does, directly, because the Clearing-House Mechanism is the piece of BBNJ infrastructure that decides what data counts. Area-based management tools, the marine protected areas and other spatial designations the Agreement exists to create in the high seas, get proposed and reviewed through that mechanism. So do environmental impact assessments for activities beyond national jurisdiction. Both

Seychelles ratified early. That gives you and SHORE standing to push for the mechanism to accept the kind of regional bathymetric and habitat data the Western Indian Ocean actually has, rather than defaulting to formats built for well-resourced Global North contributors.

processes need bathymetric, habitat and species distribution data to run on, and the mechanism is still deciding what formats, resolutions and metadata standards it will accept.

That is a hydrospatial data governance question, not a legal one, and it is being settled now, before COP1 rather than after. If the Clearing-House Mechanism defaults to the data standards and submission formats that well-funded Global North institutions already use, coastal states without that infrastructure, including most of the Western Indian Ocean, start the BBNJ era at a structural disadvantage. Seychelles ratified the Agreement early, which gives it and organisations like SHORE a credible platform to argue for standards that accommodate the mapping capacity SIDS states actually have, rather

than the capacity a handful of large maritime nations have.

There is a second thread worth tracking. Marine genetic resources and benefit-sharing, the part of BBNJ that drew the most negotiating attention for years, still needs its monetary and non-monetary benefit-sharing mechanisms worked out in practice, not just on paper. The Preparatory Commission's work on this stayed largely procedural through PrepCom3, which means the substantive fight over how SIDS states actually capture value from marine genetic resource research done in their waters, or near them, is still ahead. That is a science-to-policy pipeline problem, and it is one Shorelines readers who work in ocean governance will want a clear explainer on before COP1, not after the fact.

For SHORE specifically, the practical move is to get a position, even an informal one, into the record before January 2027.

PrepCom3's summary report is public and gives the shape of what COP1 will be asked to adopt. Reading it now, and drafting a short technical note on Clearing-House Mechanism data standards for SIDS hydrospatial capacity, is a concrete Shorelines piece that positions you ahead of the COP rather than reacting to it after the fact. The window to influence early practice is between now and January, not after.

Source: [IISD Earth Negotiations Bulletin — PrepCom3 summary report](#)

28.7% of the Seafloor Is Now Mapped. Where Is the Western Indian Ocean's Number?

28.7%

of the global ocean floor now mapped — up from roughly 24% a year ago

Seabed 2030 just added five million square kilometres of new bathymetry in a single year, and every one of those

grid cells is raw material your Ocean Mapping Hub work depends on existing at all.

STORY NOTES

The Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 Project's latest count puts global ocean floor mapping at 28.7%, roughly 104 million square kilometres, after adding close to five million square kilometres of new data in the past year. The GEBCO_2026 Grid, the eighth grid the project has produced, was published in April, built on the SRTM15+ base grid plus contributions from the four Seabed 2030 Regional Centres.

The regional numbers matter more to you than the global headline. The ROPME Sea Area, the Gulf, more than tripled its coverage this year, from roughly 6.4% to 20.5%. That is what

STORY ARTICLE

Global ocean floor mapping now stands at 28.7 percent, the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 Project confirmed in its latest annual update. That is roughly 104 million square kilometres of seafloor with usable bathymetric data. The past year alone added nearly five million square kilometres, and the project's eighth data product, the GEBCO_2026 Grid, was published in April to fold all of it into one public dataset.

The regional breakdown is the part worth sitting with. The ROPME Sea Area, covering the Gulf, jumped from about 6.4 percent coverage to 20.5 percent in a single year, more than tripling. That did not happen by accident. It happened because

targeted regional mapping effort looks like when it is resourced, and it is the model for what Western Indian Ocean coverage could do with a comparable regional push.

All of it is free and public through the GEBCO grid. That is the leverage point: the data exists to build a Western Indian Ocean regional case study, the coverage gap is now measurable rather than assumed, and the funding argument writes itself once you have the number.

regional states and Seabed 2030's Regional Centre structure targeted that basin specifically, pooled contributions, and processed them into the grid on a defined timeline. It is proof that a coordinated regional push, not just incidental crowdsourced data, is what moves the coverage number.

The Western Indian Ocean does not have a public figure attached to this update, which is itself informative. If the ROPME Sea Area's jump is documented and headline-worthy, the absence of an equivalent Western Indian Ocean figure suggests the region is either undercounted in Seabed 2030's regional reporting or genuinely under-mapped relative to comparable basins. Either way, that is a gap SHORE is positioned to name precisely, using the same GEBCO grid data that is free and public, rather than arguing

from a general sense that the region lacks coverage.

This is where the Seabed 2030 milestone turns into a funding argument rather than a status update. Multilateral and bilateral bathymetric mapping funding tends to follow demonstrated gaps, not general appeals, and the ROPME precedent is the exact comparison to draw: a defined regional coverage percentage, a funded regional mapping push, a measurable jump within twelve months. Building that same case for the Western Indian Ocean, anchored in GEBCO's own published coverage statistics rather than estimates, is a stronger pitch to IOC-UNESCO, the Nippon Foundation, or bilateral partners than a general ocean mapping capacity appeal.

There is also a direct Ocean Mapping Hub angle. Every crowdsourced bathymetry contribution submitted through Seabed 2030's four Regional Centres becomes part of the next grid release, which means the Hub's own data, if formatted and submitted correctly, has a direct and traceable path into a dataset used globally for maritime boundary work, habitat modelling, and tsunami risk assessment. That pipeline is worth documenting properly in a Shorelines piece: not just that the Hub collects data, but exactly how a single survey line becomes part of the international bathymetric record other researchers and policymakers will cite for years.

Source: [Seabed 2030 — global mapping milestone announcement](#)

N°03

 **ACT ON THIS**

COP29 PRESIDENCY–COMMONWEALTH FUND — SIDS EQUITY

US\$200,000 Is Open to Seychelles's Government Right Now

Seychelles's government is eligible right now for up to US\$200,000 from a fund built specifically for the 25 Commonwealth SIDS, and shaping that proposal around ocean health data rather than generic resilience language is where SHORE can add real value before it's submitted.

STORY NOTES

The COP29 Presidency–Commonwealth Fund for Small Island Developing States

STORY ARTICLE

Up to US\$200,000 is available to Seychelles's government right now,

opened its call for proposals in June 2026, during London Climate Action Week. It is a US\$5 million fund, jointly run by the Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency, offering grants of up to US\$200,000 to each of the 25 Commonwealth SIDS governments over five years.

Priority areas are explicit: climate resilience, ocean health, and sustainable energy, with named eligible activities including marine protection, sustainable fisheries, early warning systems, and resilient renewable infrastructure. One government-backed project per country is expected to be funded.

No public deadline is listed yet in what the Commonwealth Secretariat has published, which means the proposal

through the COP29 Presidency– Commonwealth Fund for Small Island Developing States, and the application window appears to still be open. The fund launched in June 2026 at London Climate Action Week, jointly backed by the Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency, with US\$5 million total earmarked to support one government-backed project in each of the 25 Commonwealth SIDS over the next five years.

The priority areas read like a checklist built for exactly the kind of work SHORE does: climate resilience, ocean health, and a just energy transition, with the Commonwealth Secretariat naming marine protection, sustainable fisheries, early warning systems, climate risk planning, and nature-based solutions as eligible activities. This is not a fund competing for attention

window is open now rather than closing soon. That is the moment to get in front of the relevant ministry with a specific, data-anchored ocean health component, before the proposal gets drafted around generic resilience language instead.

Apply / read the call:

<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-and-cop29-presidency-invite-commonwealth-sids-submit-climate-action-proposals>

against unrelated development priorities. It is a fund built for ocean-health projects specifically, in a pool of only 25 eligible governments, several of which have far less mapping and monitoring capacity than Seychelles already has.

That last point matters more than it might seem. A proposal built around vague resilience language, the kind every SIDS government could submit with minor edits, competes on the same footing as everyone else's generic version. A proposal that names a specific ocean health gap, backed by actual bathymetric or habitat data and a defined monitoring output, stands out in a pool where most applicants will not have that data infrastructure behind them. Seychelles has SHORE. Most of the other 24 Commonwealth SIDS do not have an equivalent institute.

The Commonwealth Secretariat has not published a hard deadline in its public announcement, which cuts both ways. It means there is no immediate cliff edge forcing a rushed submission, but it also means the window could close with limited notice once the fund reaches its five-year allocation targets in early applicant countries. Two joint flagship projects were already launched in April 2026, ahead of this broader call, which suggests the fund is moving from announcement to disbursement faster than a typical multilateral grant cycle.

The practical step is not to wait for a deadline announcement. It is to reach the relevant line ministry, likely Environment or Blue Economy, now, with a one-page concept note that proposes a specific, fundable ocean health output: a defined mapping or monitoring deliverable, a clear

budget line within the US\$200,000 ceiling, and language that ties directly to the fund's own stated priorities rather than general climate resilience framing. Getting that concept note in front of the ministry before the government's own proposal gets drafted is the difference between SHORE being consulted after the fact and SHORE shaping what gets submitted.

Source: [Commonwealth Secretariat — funding call for Commonwealth SIDS](#)

Five Years of Western Indian Ocean Regeneration, Now Documented

The Great Blue Wall's first five-year Impact Report just made the case, with numbers, for the exact Western Indian Ocean regeneration work SHORE sits next to, and it's evidence a funding pitch can cite directly instead of arguing from scratch.

STORY NOTES

On 1 April 2026 the world passed 10.01% of the ocean formally protected, roughly five million

STORY ARTICLE

Ten percent of the ocean is now formally within protected or conserved areas, a threshold the world crossed on 1 April 2026 after adding

square kilometres added in two years, an area bigger than the European Union. Two months later, at the Our Ocean Conference in Mombasa, the Great Blue Wall initiative released its first Impact Report, covering 2021 to 2025, documenting five years of ocean regeneration work across the Western Indian Ocean specifically.

This is your region. Great Blue Wall spans the same coastal and marine geography SHORE works in, and an Impact Report with five years of documented outcomes is a citable evidence base, not a pilot with no track record. That distinction is what separates a funding pitch that gets taken seriously from one that reads as aspirational.

roughly five million square kilometres of coverage in two years, an area larger than the European Union. That is a genuine milestone against SDG 14's own target of 30 percent by 2030, though it also means seven-tenths of the distance is still ahead on a four-year clock.

The more useful story for your work sits two months later. At the 11th Our Ocean Conference in Mombasa in June 2026, the Great Blue Wall initiative released its first Impact Report, covering the initiative's first five years, 2021 to 2025. Great Blue Wall is a Western Indian Ocean regeneration effort, the same geography SHORE operates in, and a five-year impact report is a different category of document to a launch announcement or a strategy paper. It has outcomes attached to it, evidence that large-scale ocean regeneration in this specific region is underway and measurable rather than aspirational.

The 10% global milestone puts pressure on the remaining 90%, and BBNJ's entry into force is the main legal channel through which more of that gets designated in the high seas. Western Indian Ocean states that can point to a documented regional model, the kind the Great Blue Wall report now provides, are better positioned in that next round of designations than states arguing from intent alone.

That distinction is what a funding pitch actually needs. Multilateral and bilateral funders see hundreds of ocean conservation proposals a year, most of them arguing from intent: here is what we plan to do, here is why it matters. A proposal that instead cites a five-year regional impact report, published by IUCN and partner governments, showing what regeneration work in the same waters has already delivered, argues from evidence instead of ambition. If SHORE's work touches any part of the Great Blue Wall geography or a comparable Western Indian Ocean initiative, citing this report directly, with its specific figures rather than a general reference to regional conservation progress, is the difference between a credible pitch and a generic one.

There is a second-order effect worth tracking too. Crossing 10 percent global ocean protection increases pressure on the remaining 90 percent, and the main legal channel for expanding

protection into the high seas is BBNJ, now in force and heading toward COP1 in January 2027. Area-based management tools, the mechanism BBNJ uses to designate new protected zones beyond national jurisdiction, will draw on exactly the kind of regional evidence base the Great Blue Wall report represents. Western Indian Ocean states that walk into that process with a documented five-year track record are arguing from a position other regions without an equivalent report cannot match.

The immediate move is to read the Impact Report in full rather than the summary coverage, pull out the specific hectare or species-recovery figures relevant to SHORE's own geography, and use them as the evidence base for whatever funding or partnership conversation is next on the calendar. A regional track record this well documented does not come along often, and it has a shelf life before newer data supersedes it.


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05

ISA / NOAA — GOVERNANCE FLASHPOINT

The Multilateral Seabed Regime Just Failed Its First Real Stress Test

While the International Seabed Authority stalls on exploitation rules, the United States just approved the first-ever unilateral deep-sea mining license outside that framework entirely, and that precedent is the single biggest threat to the multilateral seabed governance model HARMONiSE assumes will hold.

STORY NOTES

The ISA Council's March 2026 session in Kingston, Jamaica ended without finalising the Draft Exploitation Regulations, despite over a decade of negotiation, and pushed intersessional work through to a second session later in the year. Meanwhile, under an April 2025 executive order, NOAA amended the US Deep Seabed Hard Mineral Resources Act and in March 2026 found that TMC USA's consolidated application, the first under the streamlined domestic process, was in substantial compliance with statutory requirements, for both an exploration and a commercial recovery license.

This is two competing governance tracks running in parallel: a multilateral one, the ISA, still negotiating the rules it

STORY ARTICLE

Two seabed governance systems are now operating on the same physical seafloor, and they disagree about who is in charge. The International Seabed Authority, the multilateral body created under UNCLOS to regulate mineral extraction in international waters, ended its March 2026 Council session in Kingston without finalising the Draft Exploitation Regulations it has been negotiating for more than a decade. The Council pushed intersessional work through the following months and scheduled a further session later in the year, still without a finished rulebook.

The United States, which never ratified UNCLOS and is not bound by the ISA's authority, moved in the opposite direction. Under an executive order signed in April 2025, NOAA amended the domestic Deep Seabed Hard Mineral Resources Act to

needs before it can legally authorise commercial mining, and a unilateral one, the US, acting under domestic law outside a treaty it never ratified, moving toward commercial licensing without waiting for the ISA to finish.

For anyone working in maritime boundary or ocean governance policy, this is the live test case for whether the multilateral seabed regime holds when a major power decides not to wait for it. The outcome shapes precedent for every other unilateral claim to areas beyond national jurisdiction, not just seabed minerals.

create a consolidated application process, allowing a single filing to cover both an exploration license and a commercial recovery license. In March 2026, NOAA determined that the first application filed under this streamlined process, submitted by TMC USA LLC, was in substantial compliance with US statutory requirements. That is a procedural finding, not a final approval, but it moves a private company closer to commercial deep-sea mining outside the ISA's framework than any actor has come before.

The significance is not really about minerals. It is about which governance model prevails when a major power decides multilateral process is too slow. The ISA's decade-plus delay on exploitation rules is a real failure of institutional pace, and it is the exact opening a state acting under domestic law

needs to argue that unilateral action is reasonable when the multilateral body cannot finish its own rulebook. If that argument holds for seabed minerals, it holds, in principle, for other activities in areas beyond national jurisdiction that a state decides it does not want to wait on a treaty body to authorise.

That is precisely the environment BBNJ enters as it heads toward COP1 in January 2027. BBNJ assumes states will route new activity in the high seas, marine protected area proposals, environmental impact assessments, benefit-sharing from marine genetic resources, through its own multilateral machinery. A precedent where the world's largest economy instead licenses seabed activity unilaterally, justified partly by the multilateral body's own institutional delay, is a direct challenge to that assumption, whether or

not the two regimes ever formally collide in the same waters.

For SIDS states and institutes like SHORE that have staked real capacity-building effort on the multilateral model, the practical question is not whether this precedent is legally sound, that fight will run in courts and diplomatic channels for years, but whether it changes the incentive calculus for other states watching. If unilateral seabed licensing proceeds without meaningful consequence, other states with the capacity to act outside multilateral frameworks may conclude the same approach works elsewhere in ocean governance. Tracking how the ISA's next intersessional session and the TMC USA license proceed together, rather than as separate stories, is the clearest signal available right now for whether the

multilateral seabed regime survives its first
real unilateral stress test.

Source: [Greenberg Traurig — NOAA finalises deep seabed
mining rule changes](#)

Two Cost Barriers to Satellite Bathymetry Just Disappeared

Copernicus Marine just made global 100-metre-resolution coastal bathymetry free and public, and that is exactly the kind of open dataset the Ocean Mapping Hub should be citing as baseline data instead of commissioning from scratch.

STORY NOTES

Copernicus Marine Service expanded its coastal data catalogue with new global satellite-derived bathymetry products, delivering 100-metre-resolution depth

STORY ARTICLE

Two releases, six months apart, have quietly removed the two biggest cost barriers to running satellite-derived bathymetry work out of a small institute. Copernicus Marine Service, the EU's

information for coastal waters, built from satellite imagery rather than in-situ survey. Separately, an open-source SDB GUI tool, version 4.1.1, was published in March 2026, a free Python-based interface for processing satellite-derived bathymetry without commercial software licensing.

Satellite-derived bathymetry has a real limitation set, coastal and shallow-water accuracy depends on water clarity and depth, and it will not replace multibeam survey for navigational-grade charting. But for baseline regional coverage in a data-poor coastal zone, it closes gaps that would otherwise sit unmapped indefinitely.

The combination, free global coastal data plus a free open-source processing

operational ocean monitoring programme, expanded its catalogue with global coastal satellite-derived bathymetry products at 100-metre resolution, free and public, built from optical satellite imagery rather than ship-based survey. And an open-source processing tool, SDB GUI, reached version 4.1.1 in March 2026, a Python-based interface that handles the machine-learning pipeline satellite-derived bathymetry needs, including integrated ICESat-2 laser altimetry retrieval, without requiring a commercial GIS licence to run it.

Satellite-derived bathymetry works by inferring depth from how light attenuates through water in different spectral bands, calibrated against reference depth points. It is not a replacement for multibeam sonar survey, and its accuracy degrades with water turbidity and depth, generally useful

tool, removes both cost barriers that typically keep this kind of capability out of a small institute's reach. That is worth testing directly against Seychelles's own coastal waters as a Hub proof of concept.

to somewhere between 15 and 25 metres in clear water, less in anything murkier. Navigational charting still needs ship-based survey. But for a coastal state trying to establish baseline bathymetric coverage across a large EEZ with limited survey vessel time, satellite-derived bathymetry is the only method that can plausibly cover the whole coastline in a single pass, repeated over time to track change.

That is the specific gap the Ocean Mapping Hub sits in front of. Seychelles's EEZ is large relative to its survey capacity, and any coastal or nearshore area that has not had a dedicated multibeam campaign run against it is effectively unmapped for planning purposes. Global 100-metre coastal data from Copernicus, cross-referenced against whatever in-situ survey points SHORE already holds for calibration, gives a first-pass baseline for exactly

those unmapped stretches, at zero data acquisition cost. The processing tool removes the second constraint, the need for a licensed remote sensing suite or in-house machine learning pipeline to turn the raw imagery into a usable depth grid.

The honest caveat belongs in any Shorelines piece on this: satellite-derived bathymetry baseline data is a starting point, not a finished product, and any output built from it should be labelled by its actual accuracy tier rather than presented as survey-grade. The value is in coverage, not precision. Where it earns its place is habitat modelling, first-pass hazard screening, and identifying which specific coastal stretches most urgently need a proper multibeam campaign, turning a vague need for more mapping capacity into a data-backed prioritisation of where the next survey budget should actually go.

The practical next step is a direct test: pull the Copernicus coastal tile for a stretch of Seychelles's coastline SHORE already has calibration points for, run it through SDB GUI, and compare the output against known depths. If the accuracy holds at the resolution Copernicus claims, that becomes a concrete, citable proof of concept for a Hub capability that currently exists only as a plan.

Source: [Copernicus Marine Service — global coastal SDB launch](#)

Someone Is About to Become Seychelles's Gatekeeper to BBNJ Data

“The Clearing-House Mechanism is the piece of BBNJ infrastructure that decides what data counts, and the national focal point is the first filter on what reaches it.”

Parties to BBNJ are being asked to name a national focal point for the Clearing-House Mechanism right now, and whoever Seychelles's government designates for that role becomes the single point of contact shaping how the

country's own ocean data gets submitted and used under the Agreement.

STORY NOTES

Under Notification 2026-001, the UN Division for Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea has invited Parties to the BBNJ Agreement to designate a national focal point, the liaison who sends and receives official notifications and communications under the Agreement and manages information flow at the national level.

This is a narrow administrative step with outsized downstream consequences. The Clearing-House Mechanism, still being designed ahead of COP1, is the channel through which area-based management tool proposals, environmental impact assessment

STORY ARTICLE

A short administrative notification is quietly one of the more consequential BBNJ documents to land this year. Notification 2026-001, issued by the UN Division for Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea, invites every Party to the BBNJ Agreement to designate a national focal point, the individual or office responsible for sending and receiving official notifications under the Agreement and acting as the country's liaison with the secretariat.

On paper this reads like routine diplomatic housekeeping, the kind of procedural step that accompanies any treaty entering into force. In practice, the focal point role sits directly upstream of decisions that matter far more than the appointment itself

information, and marine genetic resource data move between Parties. The national focal point is the person who decides what gets submitted and how, at least until the mechanism's procedures are formally settled.

Seychelles ratified early, which means this designation decision is likely already in motion inside government. Whether SHORE or a comparable technical body gets consulted on who fills that role, or on what data standards they push for, is worth raising with the relevant ministry now, before the appointment is finalised.

Read the notification:

<https://www.un.org/bbnjagreement/en/notification-2026-001>

suggests. The Clearing-House Mechanism, the digital and administrative infrastructure through which BBNJ's substantive work happens, area-based management tool proposals, environmental impact assessment information, marine genetic resource notifications, routes through national focal points, particularly during this pre-COP1 period while the mechanism's formal procedures are still being finalised. Whoever holds that role for Seychelles is, in effect, the first filter on what national ocean data reaches the international process and how it is framed when it does.

This matters specifically because the Clearing-House Mechanism's data standards are not yet fixed. Research published in *Frontiers in Ocean Sustainability* has already raised the question of how the mechanism should

handle data-centric capacity development for Parties without extensive existing data infrastructure, precisely the situation most SIDS states are in relative to major maritime nations. A national focal point who understands hydrospatial data formats, and who is positioned to advocate for the country's actual data capacity rather than a generic administrative process, changes what Seychelles is able to contribute and access through the mechanism from day one.

For SHORE, this is not a story to read passively. If Seychelles's government has not yet finalised who will hold the national focal point role, or if the decision is being made without technical input on what the role actually requires once the Clearing-House Mechanism goes live, that is a gap worth closing now. A focal point without hydrospatial data background may default

to whatever submission format the mechanism suggests, rather than pushing for one that fits the kind of survey and habitat data SHORE and Seychelles's marine spatial planning process actually generate.

The window here is short and specific. Notification 2026-001 does not set a hard deadline in what has been published, but PrepCom3's conclusion and the run-up to COP1 in January 2027 mean early-appointed focal points will be the ones shaping how the mechanism actually operates in its first working months, before later appointees are even in position. Raising this directly with the ministry responsible for BBNJ implementation, ideally with a specific case for why the focal point role needs hydrospatial data fluency, is a concrete, low-cost intervention with a real chance of shaping

outcomes rather than reacting to them a year from now.

Source: [UN DOALOS — Notification 2026-001, national focal points](#)

The Ocean Needs \$175 Billion a Year. Seychelles Can't Access Most of It.

The ocean needs \$175 billion a year to hit SDG 14, and the gap between that figure and what actually flows to SIDS states is the exact argument your High-Income SIDS Paradox research exists to make concrete.

STORY NOTES

A blue deal, an urgent scale-up of public and private investment in sustainable ocean sectors, is needed to close the gap to \$175 billion in annual financing required for SDG 14, according to

discussion at the 5th UN Ocean Forum, hosted by UNCTAD, on trade and innovation in the blue economy.

The headline figure is not new territory. What is useful is what it implies for a

country like Seychelles: high GDP per capita by World Bank classification, which excludes it from most concessional climate finance windows, while its blue economy financing need is structurally identical to lower-income SIDS peers.

This is the High-Income SIDS Paradox in a single data point. A global financing gap this large, discussed at a UN-convened forum, is the kind of context that makes the argument for income-blind, vulnerability-based finance criteria land with numbers behind it rather than as an abstract equity claim.

STORY ARTICLE

\$175 billion a year. That is the financing gap UNCTAD's 5th UN Ocean Forum put back on the table for what sustainable ocean sectors actually need annually to reach SDG 14, and the forum's own framing called for a blue deal, an urgent scale-up of both public and private investment, to close it. The number itself is not new. What is worth pulling apart is who is positioned to access that financing when it moves, and who is not, because that split is the High-Income SIDS Paradox made concrete rather than argued in the abstract.

Multilateral climate and blue economy finance is still largely gated by income classification. The World Bank's GNI-per-capita thresholds determine eligibility for a wide range of concessional windows, and Seychelles, by that measure, sits in the high-income bracket. That classification exists for good statistical reasons at a global level. It also produces a specific distortion for small island states: GDP per capita measured at the

national level says nothing about physical exposure to sea-level rise, storm intensity, or the structural cost of building climate-resilient infrastructure across a widely dispersed archipelago. A country can be classified high-income and still face a blue economy financing need that is, in absolute structural terms, closer to its lower-income SIDS peers than to any continental high-income economy.

This is precisely the gap a \$175 billion annual financing shortfall makes visible. If the total need is that large, and concessional windows are the primary channel through which SIDS states typically access blue economy and climate finance, then income-classification exclusions do not just affect a handful of edge-case countries. They remove entire categories of small island states, Seychelles included, from a meaningful share of whatever new capital a blue deal is meant to mobilise, at the exact moment the total pool is being framed as urgently insufficient.

The argument that vulnerability, not income, should gate blue economy finance eligibility is not new either. What has been missing from that argument, consistently, is a large, current, credibly sourced figure to anchor it against. A \$175 billion annual gap, cited at a UN-convened forum in 2026, is exactly that anchor. It turns a claim that Seychelles is unfairly excluded from concessional finance into a claim that Seychelles is excluded from access to a share of a documented \$175 billion annual shortfall that vulnerability-based criteria would meaningfully close, which is a different and much stronger case to make in a policy brief, a funding pitch, or a Shorelines piece aimed at donor or multilateral audiences.

The next Shorelines piece on the High-Income SIDS Paradox should use this figure directly, alongside Seychelles's own blue bond and blue economy GDP contribution data, to build the quantitative case rather than the qualitative one. Naming the specific concessional windows Seychelles is excluded from by income classification, and estimating what share of the \$175 billion gap vulnerability-based criteria would actually unlock for high-income SIDS states, converts an equity argument that is easy to nod along to into one that is harder to dismiss with a generic reference to Seychelles's GDP per capita.

Source: [UNCTAD — 5th UN Ocean Forum, blue economy finance](#)



ACADEMIC PUBLISHING — OCEAN & GEOSCIENCE JOURNALS

Publishing Is Splitting Into Two Price Tiers, and You Should Pick Now

Where you eventually publish your graduate research just got more expensive by design, since Elsevier's Journal of Ocean Engineering and Science is converting fully to gold open access with an article processing charge attached, and that shift is happening across ocean journals faster than the funding to cover it.

STORY NOTES

The Journal of Ocean Engineering and Science becomes a fully gold open access title from 1 January 2026, joining

STORY ARTICLE

Publishing in ocean science is quietly sorting itself into two different economic models, and which side of that split you

Elsevier's roster of over 890 fully open access journals. Authors submitting from 1 November 2025 onward will be charged an article processing charge after peer review and acceptance; submissions received earlier are exempt.

This is one journal in a broader shift.

Journal of Geophysical Research:

Oceans already charges close to \$4,190 for optional open access. Some smaller society-run journals are moving the opposite direction, the Oceanographic Society of Japan dropped its manuscript listing fee entirely in January 2026 specifically to lower participation barriers.

For someone weighing where to publish graduate research on a SIDS researcher's budget, the practical effect

land on will shape where graduate research work can realistically go. The Journal of Ocean Engineering and Science converts to fully gold open access from 1 January 2026, part of Elsevier's push past 890 fully open access titles. Every article submitted from 1 November 2025 onward is charged an article processing charge once it clears peer review, a cost that did not previously exist for that journal and now sits between authors and publication regardless of institutional backing.

This is not an isolated policy change.

Journal of Geophysical Research: Oceans, one of the field's most cited venues, already charges close to \$4,190 for its own open access option. These are not small numbers against a graduate stipend or an early-career researcher's discretionary budget, and they compound the moment a project has co-authors, multiple papers, or

is a widening split between commercial gold-OA journals charging thousands per article and smaller open, no-fee venues, and that split is worth mapping deliberately before choosing a target journal, not discovering after a manuscript is drafted.

supplementary data publications attached to a single piece of research.

Set against that, a smaller, quieter shift is moving the opposite direction. The Oceanographic Society of Japan eliminated its manuscript listing fee entirely in January 2026, regardless of membership status, explicitly to lower the barrier to publishing for authors without institutional funding behind them. The European Geosciences Union's full journal portfolio remains open access without the same fee structure commercial publishers are converting toward. These venues exist, they are credible, and they are being drowned out in general conversation by the scale of the commercial shift happening around them.

The practical implication is that where research should go is no longer a question

answerable by journal prestige and topic fit alone. It now has a real cost dimension that needs mapping before a manuscript is drafted, not discovered after submission when an invoice for several thousand dollars arrives with an acceptance letter. For graduate research undertaken without a large institutional grant behind it, the fully gold open access commercial journals are increasingly the expensive default, while the fee-free or lower-fee venues require deliberately seeking out rather than falling into by habit.

There is a second-order point worth raising in a Shorelines piece on this, beyond the personal publishing-strategy angle. If commercial gold open access becomes the field's dominant model, and article processing charges sit in the thousands of dollars, that is a structural barrier to publication for researchers

based in SIDS institutions generally, not just an individual budgeting problem. A researcher at a well-funded Global North university absorbs a large article processing charge as a normal grant line item. A SIDS-based researcher, or an independent institute like SHORE, does not have that grant infrastructure as a default. Naming that gap explicitly, with the actual fee figures attached, is a stronger contribution to the open access equity conversation than a general complaint about publishing costs, and it is worth writing before choosing where the next SHORE research output goes.

Source: [ScienceDirect — Journal of Ocean Engineering and Science, OA policy](#)

You Missed the Rio 2027 Door. Don't Miss the Next One.

The 2027 Ocean Decade Conference in Rio is where the Decade's next phase gets set, and even though the Special Events call already closed, the pattern behind it is the thing worth acting on now so the next window doesn't close unnoticed too.

STORY NOTES

The 2027 Ocean Decade Conference runs 7 to 9 April 2027 in Rio de Janeiro, hosted by the Brazilian government and co-organised with IOC-UNESCO,

STORY ARTICLE

Rio de Janeiro hosts the 2027 Ocean Decade Conference from 7 to 9 April, co-organised by the Brazilian government and IOC-UNESCO, with roughly 3,000

expected to draw around 3,000 participants, preceded by two days of Special Events on 5 and 6 April dedicated to individual Ocean Decade Solutions or specific ocean regions.

The call for institutions to lead those Special Events closed 31 August 2026, so that specific door is shut. What is still open is everything downstream: the main conference programme, side events, and the broader positioning window as the Ocean Decade heads into its back half toward 2030.

A Western Indian Ocean or SIDS-focused Special Event evidently was not on SHORE's radar in time this round. Worth flagging now, plainly, so the same window does not close unnoticed again

participants expected. It is preceded by two days of dedicated Special Events on 5 and 6 April, each built around one of the UN Ocean Decade's eight defined Solutions or a specific ocean region, running as full-day programmes ahead of the main conference.

The call for institutions to lead those Special Events closed on 31 August 2026. That window is shut, and there is no value in treating it as still open. What is worth doing instead is naming clearly why it matters that it passed without a Western Indian Ocean or SIDS-focused proposal from SHORE or an aligned partner institution going in, and making sure the next comparable window does not close the same way.

The Ocean Decade Solutions framework groups the Decade's priorities into named

when the next Ocean Decade milestone event opens its own call.

categories, spanning ocean mapping, biodiversity conservation, pollution, sustainable food, climate, resilience, technology and knowledge, and capacity development. A Special Event dedicated to any one of these, framed specifically around Western Indian Ocean or SIDS hydrospatial equity, would have put SHORE's core work directly in front of the roughly 3,000 people the main conference is expected to draw, a scale of visibility that is difficult to replicate through a Shorelines post or a single conference panel slot elsewhere.

This is not a story with an immediate action attached to it, since the specific door named in this update is closed. It is a story worth logging precisely because it establishes a pattern: major Ocean Decade milestone events run on calls with lead times of six to eight months, publicised

through channels like IOCARIBE, IOC-UNESCO's own news feed, and partner networks like GEO Blue Planet, rather than through a single centralised announcement. Missing the Rio 2027 Special Events call is a reasonable one-off. Missing the equivalent call for whatever comes after Rio, or for regional Ocean Decade Actions calls that open on a rolling basis throughout the year, would not be.

The practical takeaway is procedural rather than urgent: set a standing watch on IOC-UNESCO, IOCARIBE, and Ocean Decade's own news channel for the next call of this kind, and treat any future special event, decade action, or flagship programme call as a deadline to calendar the moment it appears, not something to notice after the fact once the window has already closed, as happened this time.

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